Tall, lithe and sure-footed, only 75 kg for his 6'1" frame, he covered the court like a llama might canter over an Andean slope. Prakash Padukone also straddled two parallel styles: touch artistry and power. If his deft drop shots were arguments, they would have been duplicitous: looking east, going west. But he also had a lethal half-smash that went straight as an arrow. More than everything, there was that supreme spatial-temporal court intelligence. Which shot to play, when, where. Listen to his own description of how he slowed down the hyper-kinetic Liem Swie King, disarming the Indonesian of his heavy weaponry, in the All England final of 1980: "I would make him move just a fraction of a second late because I was holding back my stroke. If he was expecting a toss, I would play a drop. If he was expecting a drop, I would play a stroke. He couldn't anticipate and stand there and be in an attacking position." The world also couldn't anticipate how a man from a non-badminton country, seemingly able to shrink the 44x17-foot court at will, was now going to expand it.

The All England Championship was equivalent to a tennis grand slam. And Padukone was no one-hit wonder: a serial national champ since age 17, back in 1972, the Udupi native had also swept the Swedish and Danish Opens in 1980—a long list, including the 1981 World Cup, kept him in the Top 10 for close to a decade. A lone wolf flying the Indian flag high. But that's what he changed next, in a country whose poverty extended to sporting infrastructure.

His very winnability became a tangible factor. In India, there was cricket, maybe hockey. "Shuttlecock" was evening recreation, nothing more. But soon, U. Vimal Kumar, our man at Barcelona '92 as badminton debuted at the Olympics, was sacrificing a medical seat "because we all wanted to be like Prakash". In '94 came the Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy. And, seven years later, India's next All England champ, Pullela Gopichand. The lineage lay not only in the fact that he honed his game under Padukone. "Had he not won the All England, we Indians would have never thought it was possible for us. It inspired parents like mine to put their children into the sport," says Gopi. Think now of the full spring that surrounds us, and a seed that flew out of Wembley in 1980. ■

QUITE A RACQUET

- **Prakash Padukone wins All England, badminton's highest event, in 1980**
- **In a country that looked at "shuttlecock" only as casual recreation, it sparks a slow forest fire**
- **In 1994, the Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy is set up**
- **Prakash hones the skills of Pullela Gopichand; he wins All England in 2001**
- **Like his forebear, Gopi too sets up an academy**
- **Saina Nehwal, P.V. Sindhu, Kidambi Srikanth, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, Chirag Shetty...it's a glut now**







(FROM TOP) Pullela Gopichand, Saina Nehwal and P.V. Sindhu



The Come-back Champion

FROM THE ARCHIVES
Nov. 30, 1981

Interview
The Comeback Champion

On weaknesses of Indian players
They have to improve their physical fitness and also the power of their game. As far as strokes are concerned, nobody can beat us. But it's not enough to have strokes, we need speed and fitness. To finish a rally you have to have a good smash. May not be a smash like Liem Swie King has, but a reasonably good smash to take advantage of the opening you have created.

Key factor that makes champions
You can't have everything: the speed, the stroke, the exact length and power. You've got to base your game on this or that. It's very difficult to be a perfect player. To be on top, you have to choose. I have chosen a combination.

–with Raj Chengappa